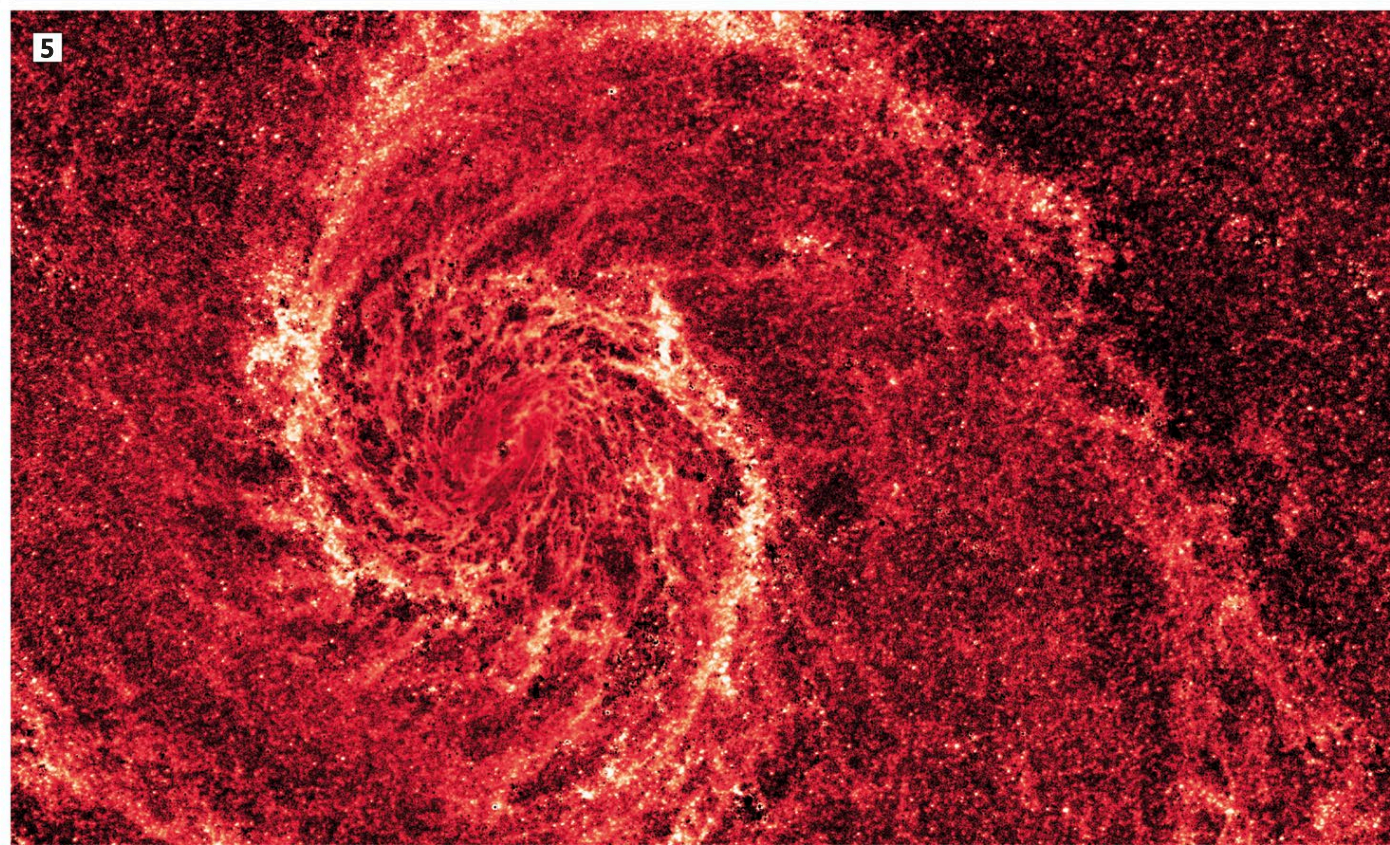
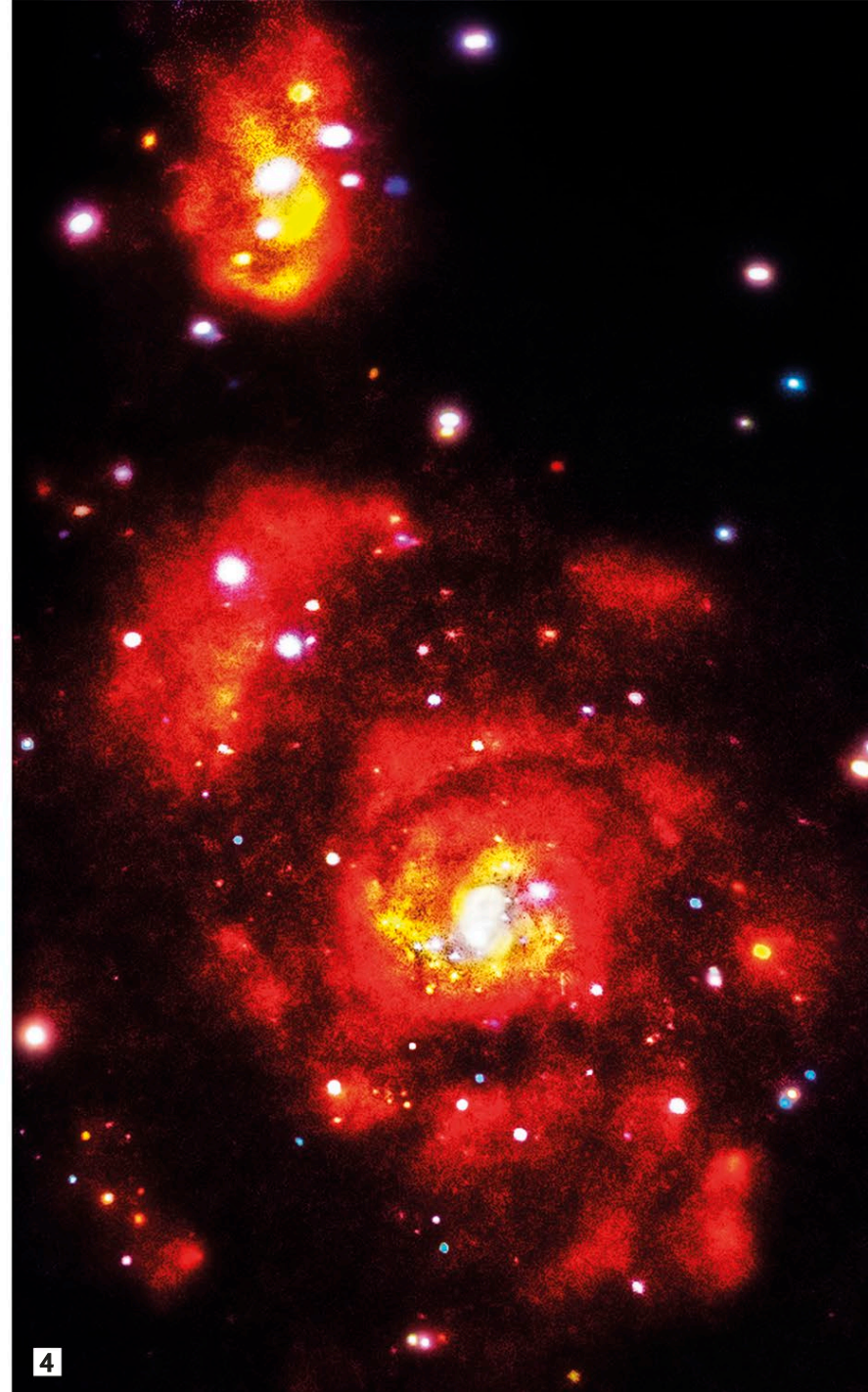
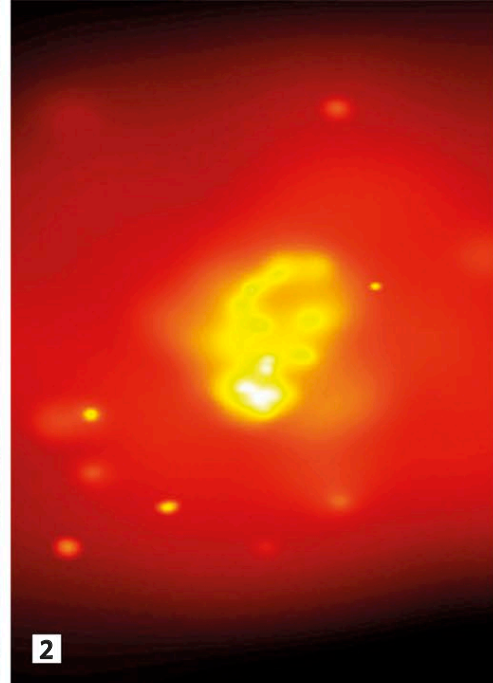




5 Dusty galaxy

Most of the galaxy's starlight is invisible when viewed in near-infrared light. Instead we see the Whirlpool's dust structure, shown here in red. The dust is tied up in smooth, diffuse dust lanes, rather than large dust clouds. These lanes are punctuated by hundreds of tiny clumps of stars, not seen in optical images because their light cannot penetrate the dark dust enshrouding them.